



The Cascade Range

A stunning array of volcanoes and other peaks in the North American West

The Cascade Range is a part of the “Ring of Fire”—a horseshoe-shaped band of volcanoes and associated mountains that encloses the Pacific Ocean. Extending 680 miles (1,100 km), the Cascades formed over the last few million years as a result of the process of subduction as the Juan de Fuca oceanic plate slides underneath the North American Plate.

Volcanic hotbed

The Cascade Range includes many large and magnificent-looking volcanoes, such as Mounts Baker, Rainier, and St. Helens in Washington; Mount Hood in Oregon; and Mount Shasta in California. Several Cascade volcanoes have erupted at least once in the last 200 years, and all volcanic eruptions during this period in the contiguous United States (the whole country other than Alaska and Hawaii) have been from Cascade volcanoes.

▽ BROODING GIANT

Glacier-shrouded Mount Rainier is considered one of the world’s most dangerous volcanoes, due to its eruption potential and its proximity to the city of Seattle.



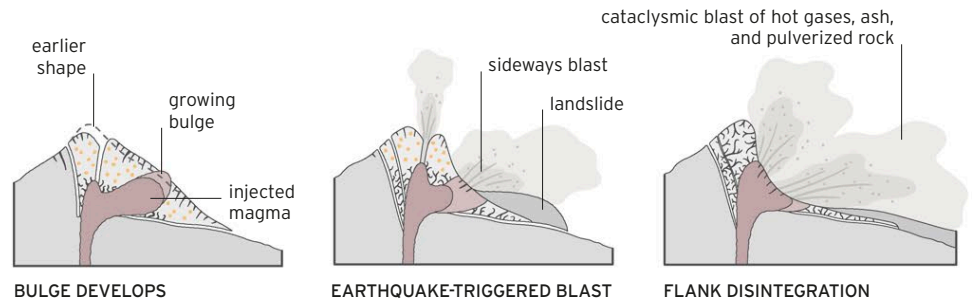
▷ MEGABLAST

The 1980 eruption of Mount St. Helens is the deadliest to have occurred in the U.S. in recorded history. Most of the ash emitted settled over vast areas of the northwestern U.S.

THE ERUPTION OF MOUNT ST. HELENS

In May 1980, a violent eruption tore apart the snow-capped peak of Mount St. Helens, the most active volcano in the Cascade Range. Before the eruption, a bulge had been growing for several weeks on the volcano’s

flank, due to magma being forced up inside. At 8:32 a.m. on May 18, an earthquake triggered a landslide and a sideways blast. This was soon followed by total disintegration of a part of the flank and the summit of the volcano.



The eruption of **Mount St. Helens** in 1980 produced an **ash plume** that **rose 15 miles (24 km)** into the air